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George Wein

George Wein was born in Boston on October 3, 1925. He has made an indelible mark in the jazz world as a pianist, record producer, club owner and founder of the Newport Jazz Festival. George has performed and recorded with a long list of jazz luminaries, including Ruby Braff, Stephane Grappelli and Buck Clayton. His talent in organizing jazz events is legendary and his formation of Festival Productions will assure that quality festivals will be available to jazz lovers here and abroad for many years to come.

George was interviewed in New York City on January 13, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe. We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in New York City. I'm especially pleased that George Wein has found a little time for me today, and I'm most appreciative.

GW: Anybody with the name of Monk can't be all bad.

MR: I'll take whatever entrance I can get, believe me. You know I usually introduce somebody as a saxophonist or whatever, and with you I'd have to spend five minutes. So everyone knows your reputation. I want to see if I can take you back a little bit. Music obviously must have been in you from the start. Can you recall as a child what music started to really make an impression on you and where did you hear it?

GW: I go back a long way, Monk. I was born in 1925. And I used to sing the pop songs when I was six and seven years old. I go back to songs, and my mother used to play a little piano and I used to sing songs like "I Want to Go Back to My Little Grass Shack in Kealakekua, Hawaii" and once in a while on a Saturday morning she'd take me down to these kiddie shows where you audition and you'd sing and then get paid. I mean it wasn't a gig but you'd sing over the radio. That was such a thrill, to sing over the radio when you're six, seven or eight years old. And I learned all the popular songs. "Darkness on the Delta," was one of my favorite tunes. And one night I was on tour with Thelonious Monk and he played an encore. He liked to play solo piano encores and he played "Darkness on the Delta." I had never heard anybody play that tune, "Darkness on the Delta" except when I sang it when I was a kid. And I said, "Thelonious, where did you learn that tune?" People don't realize that Thelonious came out of that era. And he knew all those songs. It was a great thrill for me to hear Thelonious playing "Darkness on the Delta."

MR: I suppose he gave it his own unique treatment too.

GW: It wasn't like I heard it in 1934 or whatever year it was.

MR: Wow that's neat. And you say the pop songs of the day, these were things that would be like on the radio with vocal groups?

GW: The tin pan alley songs of the 30s. All these, you know, Bob Hope had "Thanks for the Memories," all those tunes. I used to sing them all. "Hold Me Honey, Won't You Hold Me." You don't know any of those, because nobody knows those tunes.

MR: But you could go out and buy the sheet music I suppose?

GW: Yes, my mother would buy the sheet music and she could play it. She had to buy the ones she could play. She had a lot of ones she could play because she wasn't a great piano player but at least she could read a little sheet music and accompany me.

MR: Was your mother — if you said to your mother C7—

GW: No, she didn't know that at all. She didn't know anything about that.

MR: No, okay. But she could read the sheet music and so forth. Oh that's great. So you kind of naturally, you had the piano in the house. Did anybody have to push you into it?

GW: I studied classical piano when I was about seven or eight years old and I started. I played classical for about four or five years. I studied with a very famous teacher, but she wasn't famous when I studied with her, Mrs. Chaloff and she later became Madame Chaloff at the Berklee College, and her son was Serge Chaloff, Serge went to school with me. And she was a wonderful woman, and she really gave me a technique. She didn't teach me a lot about music, which was unfortunate, because that's one of the reasons I never knew more about music. But she taught me how to play the piano. Which, I still know how to play the piano but I don't have a great grounding in harmonies and voicings. But I have a lot of fun playing.

MR: Was there a point where the classical lessons just wasn't enough?

GW: They petered out and I wanted to learn how to play popular so I could — I don't know why, I didn't think of myself as a singer — but I liked to play and sing and so I wanted to accompany myself instead of having my mother accompany. Because I just sang at parties in the house, "Georgie you've got to sing a song, Georgie you've got to sing a song, Georgie you've got to sing a song." And I don't want to give you the impression I was a good singer, but I was a kid that could sing a song and I wasn't any boy wonder. But to my father and mother I was the greatest. I wasn't the greatest to anybody else, but to my mother and father I was the greatest, which is nice. When you grow up with a feeling of security and love it's nice. And the next thing I knew my brother brought home some records of Louis Armstrong and Glen Gray and Jimmie Lunceford. He ordered a little record player and got thirteen free records with the record player and they were all jazz records. He was four years older than I was and he used to go to the dances. And this was, I guess I was eleven or twelve years, I don't know. And then I really became interested in jazz. And not jazz but big band, you know, Tommy Dorsey, Benny Goodman. The next thing I knew I had formed a band. Like kids form rock & roll bands, I called — I was in junior high school — and we used to rehearse every Sunday in my

cellar at the house we had in Newton, Massachusetts, and I found four saxophones and two trombones and three trumpets and piano, bass — I was the piano player. I went out and bought stock arrangements, we all bought them. And my mother knew somebody from New York and I went down there, we took a trip, I got free arrangements from the publishers. Just like a kid has a rock & roll band, in those days I had a dance band. We used to play Tommy Dorsey's "Song of India" and Glenn Miller's "In the Mood" and Erskine Hawkins' "Tuxedo Junction" and we had a lot of fun. We used to work occasional — somebody took pity and hired us for a gig and we made two dollars a night, you know. But then I got interested in small band music and I started to learn. I studied with a great jazz teacher by the name of Sam Sax and he taught me about chords and taught me about how to play in different keys and things like that. And we'd take a standard and I'd have to play it in all twelve different keys and so I learned a lot from him. And next thing you know my name got on the list of a non-union booker while I was in high school. I was working gigs in what you'd call the buckets of blood, the Walt's Grill and the Silver Dollar Bar for two dollars a night, three dollars a night, five dollars a night, and while I was going to school. I didn't work a lot but I'd go in. I didn't know much. I didn't know any musicians we were playing with and none of us knew anything. But we did it. And we learned. And I became very involved with jazz music. And then I became friendly — friends of mine knew Lionel Hampton, they knew Frankie Newton, my brother knew Red Allen and J.C. Higginbotham and I'd sit in with them and it was a big thrill. Lionel Hampton I met when I was I think sixteen. It was at a party and he heard that I played a little piano and then I remember I sat down and played the bass while he did a two finger thing on "Lady Be Good." I mean this was — I mean what a thrill — I mean Lionel Hampton and I'm playing "Lady Be Good," the chords. And you know it gets in your blood. And a couple of nights later we went down to see Lionel at the Tic Toc Club. My mother and father were with me. My mother and father loved music. And Lionel calls me up from the audience and I'm on the stage of the Tic Toc Café with Lionel, Illinois Jacquet was in the band, Dexter Gordon. I didn't know who they were at that time. Joe Newman was in the band. And I'm playing on the stage and people are plotting the rest of your life when that happens.

MR: Isn't that interesting. You know I have to remind myself, when you talk about some of those tunes you were playing with your first band, they sound old but for you guys, that was the current music of the day, is that right?

GW: Oh yes. We were not playing old music. Old music was Bix Beiderbecke. We were playing Teddy Wilson, Benny Goodman, it was swing. That was the hip music of the day, before bebop. It was before the war and we were trying to be — you know, Duke Ellington. But I was getting into it.

MR: Did your parents like the direction you took?

GW: I had no direction. I was a kid playing the piano. I mean my folks would pick me up at one o'clock in the morning when I was playing some of these joints, and I mean they were joints. I mean I would play in joints. And they would be out in the car waiting for me. I was sixteen or seventeen years, maybe I was even fifteen years old, I don't know. I don't recall exactly. But there were a couple of years, you can't believe some of those joints in Boston, you know, they were sailor joints, there were fights and everything. And they needed non-union musicians. I mean I knew about twelve songs. And I was trying to play the others by ear and I didn't have a good ear, I did all the wrong changes. But still learning. It was a great, great period of learning.

MR: I guess you could hide behind the piano if things got too rough in there.

GW: Sometimes you did, yeah. Because the war had started and there were a lot of sailors and they would get drunk and the SPs and the MPs would come in there. I remember once they hit a guy over the head and the blood spurted up to the ceiling. But this wasn't the way I made my living, I was still a high school student in a nice middle class city of Newton, Massachusetts you know. But it was fun. And the next thing you know I was in the Army. I graduated from high school and it was 194— it was January 1944 I went in the Army and all during the Army I was never in a musical group. But we always played music. Whatever group we were in of musicians, we would form a band, and there were some good musicians there. And I really had fun playing. I was a combat engineer so I wasn't in an easy group. We were lucky that we didn't see combat. Like when we were in Europe we were waiting for — we were rehearsing to build bridges to cross the Rhine and then one day we woke up and there was what they called the Remagen bridge head, which historically was the bridge that they captured and crossed the Rhine. The Germans didn't blow it up in time. And that saved us because we never had to go in combat. But we were in England waiting to be told to go there. An outfit we had trained with at the same camp in Oklahoma, Camp Gruber, was there. And they got shot up pretty badly. So playing the piano saved a lot of problems for me in the Army because we played the officers' dances. And we'd get in trouble the officers would say, "What's the matter" when you're having a problem. I says, "No, sir, I'm fine, but this Company punishment is killing me," because I'd be talking back to a sergeant or something like that. And the next thing I'd know I'd be off Company punishment because they wanted us to be able to play the officers' dance. So playing the piano had its plusses.

MR: Excellent. Did you fellas get to listen to those V-disks that came over?

GW: In England I found them. I found them in a little, we had little huts where we could get tea and there were some record players, and there were always some V-disks there. And I didn't know what they were because we couldn't buy those. And it was great stuff with

Fats Waller and Louis and a lot of them that were not ever put out on records. Maybe some of them have been re-issued at this point. But they weren't re-issued for years. But I had a good time in the Army. I hated every minute I was in the Army. And when I got out, I mean when they dropped the bomb, the atomic bomb, which has since become such a controversial thing, I remember I was in Marseille and I sat down on a dirt road, it was a camp you know, and started to cry with relief. I was going home. So when I hear all the controversy about the atomic bomb, I can never forget my feeling when we dropped that bomb and I knew we were going home. I going to be in— But I was supposed to take a boat and be involved in the invasion to Japan. Because we were in a staging area in Marseille where you would go through the Panama Canal all the way to Japan. And I never left. And I went home. So that was an interesting part of my life.

MR: I bet you weren't alone in that feeling too.

GW: Oh everybody did. But the thing I learned in the Army that was, hey, you were only yourself. You were not Dr. Wein's son. You were not a nice Jewish kid from a middle class family. Economics, background, nothing meant anything except you, yourself. And you had to compete with the other guy. Now the other guy might have been a brilliant guy from Harvard, he might have been some poor guy from the mountains in Kentucky, he might have been a tough mug from the factories somewhere in Detroit. You had to be equal with them. You had nothing going for you except yourself, and you learned how to handle yourself. And that has been a benefit to me all of my life. And I'm very happy I went through that. I would never ask anybody to go through it again because it's — Army life is not any fun you know. It's terrible. But if you go through it, it's worth it.

MR: A lot of the musicians I've talked to have been fortunate that they were musicians, much like yourself.

GW: But I had an opportunity to go to Warrant Officer's School, which would have meant I would have had a really plush life in the Army. But somebody told me that we would go in what you call the Army Special Training Program and take Basic Training and then go to college for four years and then get a Commission and go in the Army. Well they wiped that program out and we were all thrown into the Infantry. And that was it. From the Infantry I went to the Combat Engineers. So I never had the benefit of being in a musical outfit. But because we played, we always found guys that played. On every camp that we went to there were guys that played. Even on the boat coming home there was a group of musicians on all the trip home, which in those days took eight or nine days on the ocean, ten days, you know they weren't fast ships. We'd play music all the time. So it was always a saving grace for me.

MR: I have a very short quote from the *All Music Guide to Jazz*, who describes you as "an Earl Hines-influenced pianist."

GW: Sam Sax, my teacher, was a disciple of Earl Hines. And in those days of course you didn't have Bud Powell stamps. Earl Hines was the piano player for the big bands. I loved Teddy Wilson and Earl Hines. Teddy Wilson was a refined version of Earl Hines. Earl Hines played with octaves and tremolos. Teddy played single finger. But they had the same basic approach to the music, the same melodic approach. And so I loved both of those players. And later on I studied with Teddy Wilson, when I was in college in my junior year. I came to New York and studied with him at Juilliard. And I got to know him. But all during college I was playing the piano. And then I got involved with a lot of jazz players in Boston. And then one time they had a band coming to the Ken Club in Boston with Pee Wee Russell and Max Kaminsky and Miff Mole. And they needed a Boston rhythm section. And the regular piano player that normally played those Dixieland and traditional tunes that they played wasn't available. And I knew him and he taught me the tunes and the next thing I know I was playing seven nights and Sunday afternoon for four or six weeks while I was still going to college. It was a seven day program and a Sunday afternoon program and I was still going to college. But I loved that. And at the same time that I loved that, work with Pee Wee Russell, I mean I've been in love with Pee Wee Russell ever since. And I think that that engagement was what determined that I was not going to make my life as a professional piano player. Because I saw the way that these world famous musicians lived. In cheap hotels. I was making $60 a week. They were making $120 a week. They were the stars. You know $120 a week in 1948 was a week's pay, but it sure wasn't much money for somebody that was a world famous star. Because people collected his records everywhere you went. And I think in seeing them drunk in their rooms at night, you know, and so lonely and so out of it, I said I'm not sure that this is the life I really want, even though I love playing and I love the music. And I don't think I consciously made a decision at that time. I know I didn't consciously make a decision. Because the next year I played with Edmond Hall and his quartet at the Savoy. And I was working gigs, and I was playing and I was having a ball. I was making money while I was in college. I arranged my senior year in college so I'd only have classes Monday, Wednesday and Friday so I could at least get to sleep four days a week, you know what I mean, you know in the morning when I woke up. Because I was playing so much. And when I graduated college I was playing a lot of gigs, playing in clubs, I was booking the bands at the Savoy, a jazz club in Boston and playing and getting a different band every week because the woman that owned the place said, "Why don't — since you're the piano player, — why don't you bring the musicians up from New York" because we knew them. And I found myself organizing things. And then one day somebody says, "Well why don't you open up your own club?" I mean I never had a direction, a motivation you see. I says, "I have no money to open up a club." But I had

five thousand dollars that had been saved for my education. My folks weren't rich. They had a little money but they were frugal. My father was a doctor, he never saved much money. He went to the race track every afternoon. He did his work in the morning and made enough money to support the house and lost the rest to the races. For 25 years. But it saved his life. He lived to be 96 years old. So he always said all his friends were dead, they worked too hard, but he was still alive. So I had this money because I'd went to college on the GI bill. And I made a deal with the hotel and opened up Storyville in the fall of 1950. And I've been in business ever since.

MR: It's like you were improvising from the moment, every time a moment came up.

GW: I had never been in business. I didn't know what it was to be in business, I wasn't a businessman. And I was a graduate, I was playing piano, and somebody says, "Open up a club." I opened up a club. But I knew everybody in Boston. I knew the whole jazz world. I knew all the radio people, because I'd been playing at clubs all the time. And I'd done one concert with Edmond Hall, it was Edmond Hall and George Wein present, and then Nat Hentoff wrote the liner notes, because he was a Boston D.J. at that time and a good friend of mine. And Wild Bill Davison and a few other guests. We sold out Jordan Hall. And the first promotion I ever did we sold out. A thousand tickets. So man, who knows? You're a star, right? You sold out a concert. Boy.

MR: Well as clubs go, you had a great run. I mean when you think about how quickly some clubs open and close.

GW: Well we made it for ten years. We never made any money. We couldn't make any money. But we did have good weeks. The bad weeks sapped away the money from the good weeks. So we were always, at the end of the year, we were always a few thousand dollars in the hole. We could borrow. I was drawing salary of eighty or ninety dollars a week and paying my expenses. I had a little cash in my pocket to go to restaurants and things like that. But I started the Newport Jazz Festival in 1954 when the Lorillards came into my club from Newport, Rhode Island, and they wanted to do something in Newport to make the summer a little more exciting. And Elaine Lorillard, that was the first one to come in, she brought her husband back a few nights later and a professor from Boston University said to them, because Elaine was taking some classes at BU and the professor was a jazz fan and a friend of mine, Donald Vaughan, and he said, "Why don't you get George Wein to do something with jazz in Newport?" We didn't know what to do. But I said, you know, there's a classical music festival in Tanglewood. Why can't we have our own jazz festival. And would you back a three day, two day event for jazz? And he said sure, and he authorized his bank in Newport to give me a line of credit for twenty thousand dollars, which was a fortune. I never saw that kind of money. And then they went to Capri and I got together with my people and I knew everybody in New England

that came to my club, see this was 1954. And I knew what artists would sell tickets. And I put a program together for the first festival in '54 and the next thing you know we made international news and we were off to the races with the Newport Jazz Festival. And that of course established my international reputation.

MR: And what a run you had. Unbelievable.

GW: It's been an interesting run. It is still running. Our life is busier than ever. We're doing more festivals than ever. We just signed a new deal with Verizon to do three festivals, JVC is going to stay with us another few years and we're doing festivals with Playboy in New Orleans and Mellon Bank in Pittsburgh and Philadelphia, we do the Essence Music Festival for Essence Magazine, we do events for JVC and all over, five or six different JVC festivals. The Newport Folk Festival we do still and we're back in Newport after all these years to do the big festival in New York. We do things at Saratoga, a big weekend at Saratoga. We're busy. And I've got a lot of wonderful people working for me that make it possible for me to do it.

MR: If I could ask you, mention a couple of names, and maybe the first, just something that comes to mind about them. Joe Williams?

GW: Joe Williams was a great singer. Everybody thought he was a blues singer. Well put it this way, Joe Williams could sing the blues. But he was a great ballad singer. And that's, I think in his heart he wanted to be a ballad singer. But he sang the blues as well as anybody. Big band jazz blues. He wasn't an old time blues singer with a guitar walking the streets, you know, sort of like Blind Lemon Jefferson. He was a jazz blues singer like Jimmy Rushing. Jimmy Rushing wasn't a blues singer. He sang the blues. He wanted to be a crooner. You know all these people came out of their era. Joe Williams wanted to be Frank Sinatra or Billy Eckstine. But his life became a blues singer. Great artist. Wonderful, wonderful man and when he first came to Storyville with Count Basie and was singing "Every Day," that song, you know "Every Day I Have the Blues," we knew something very exciting was happening. And he was around then as a star, right to the end of the days. And he worked for me many, many times. I loved him dearly.

MR: Good statement. What about Basie? What did you learn from Basie as perhaps — I mean the fact that he led his band for so many years.

GW: I learned a lot from Basie. I learned how to comp rhythmically. I learned how to lead a band without making a very ostentatious presentation. You didn't have to be a big shot up there waving your arms, and I learned how to pace. He knew how to pace things. Above all, if you just listen to him you learn about swinging. There's a couple of people — you learn, like Lionel Hampton and Basie — but they knew one thing, they knew how to swing. And also you learned about how to let your band stretch out without ever disrupting the structure of the number, but yet the musicians got a chance to play and

without taking over and playing too long or whatever it was. You learn how to program things. But I also learned what a great man Bill Basie was. I mean again, I love these people. You can't believe or know what they meant to me. And to be on the road — one time I was in — I'm telling you a couple of stories here for the archive. I'm going to use these in my book. We were in Burma one night. And I had said to Lockjaw Davis, Eddie Davis, in Tokyo, "You know Basie doesn't play an encore." I says, "You're the straw boss. Why don't you speak with him." He said, "Well you speak to Basie yourself." So the next day we were in Burma. We'd been sent there by the State Department. And I said, "Bill, why don't you play an encore." He says, "George," he says, "I learned one thing in Birdland. Never give them too much. Leave them wanting more so they'll come back." I said, "Bas'" I says, "I understand that completely. But when is the next time you're going to be in Burma?" That night he played an encore and he played encores the rest of the tour. And he was supposed to fly to Laos the next day. And my father was with us. I brought him along on the tour. And he loved my father. He had tremendous respect for my father. And so his contract, for him to only fly scheduled airlines, no non-scheduled airlines. But the date in Laos was an Army date and they had Army planes, bucket seats, the Vietnam war was on and so they were flying to Laos the next day. And Bas' says, "I'm not going unless you go." I says, "Man, if you want me to go I'll be there." Because I hadn't intended to go. About seven o'clock in the morning I'm at the airport, Basie's there, he says to me, "What are you doing here?" I says, "You said you weren't going unless I went so I'm going." He says, "Your father back at the hotel?" I says, "Yes." He says, "you get out of here and go back and take care of your father." He went to Laos. That's the kind of man Basie was. So, you know, it's a beautiful story.

MR: It's a lot, yeah.

GW: Basie tells it differently in his book. He says I wanted to go so I played piano with the band so he wouldn't go. That's a nice story, that's a better story than mine, but that wasn't the story. He told the story his way. He says, "George wanted to go so he could play piano with the band."

MR: Yeah, you stay home, Count. That's a good one. Wow. What about Coltrane?

GW: John Coltrane was a giant. No question he was a giant. And I have a few wonderful stories about Coltrane, but the saddest one was when I called him, I guess it was six, eight months before he died, and I wanted to do a European tour with him. Because he did go to Europe for me a couple of times. He played my festivals many times. He played Storyville with Miles and he played Japan for me. And I wasn't close to John Coltrane but I knew him well enough. I had tremendous respect for him, I guess he had a little respect for me. But I called him and I said, "John I'd like to talk to you about going to Europe." He said, "Well I don't want to talk about anything now" he says, "I'm not

eating." I says, "What kind of a regime are you on, what kind of diet you on?" He says, "I'm not on a diet, George," he says, "I'm not eating." I says, "John, you can't do that. You can't fast. I mean you have to have something, even when you fast you have to feed yourself some nourishment." He says, "No I'm not doing anything because I want to clean out my system." I didn't know what to say. I says, "John you just can't do that." So we hung up. He was dead a few months later. But he knew the sickness was inside of him. He had a liver problem you know, and all that he had absorbed, all the drugs and alcohol in his early days. And it just got to him eventually. And he was a magnificent saxophone player. And when I heard him and then I hear the people that copy him, it's two different worlds. He influenced too many saxophone players.

MR: Too many.

GW: Too many.

MR: Do you have an idea why, for that stretch of time, well for too long, that drugs were so much connected with jazz and so much a part of it?

GW: I don't have any story about why it was. I don't know. And I'm not a sociologist in any way. I do know that prior to Charlie Parker, marijuana was — because Louis Armstrong was a big influence on people smoking marijuana. Alcohol was a very big thing with musicians. A lot of musicians were heavy into alcohol — Pee Wee Russell or Vic Dickinson or J.C. Higginbotham, all the guys with Basie's band and Dickie Wells. They were real alcoholics. And so there is something about the music business and the lack of stability and the life and the road and everything that drives people into substitute drugs and substances or anything that can give you a lift or take you out of the reality of the, really, not such a nice life you're living. Because the only good life is when you're on the stand playing the music. The rest of the time you're living in — in those days you're living in two bit hotels and eating junk for your dinner and you had no money. Nobody made any money. The guys in Basie's band, Ellington's band, I don't care what night club players, they were playing 52nd Street for $40 a week. All this great legendary time, when you read about what a great place 52nd — it was great for everybody, but the musicians were making nothing. And so they needed something. And there were always people that led the way. Bird came along and he was into drugs. And Bird took over — I mean Bird completely wiped out people's minds with the way he played. Nobody had ever heard that, and everybody wanted to play like that and be part of it. And I guess they thought they had to be on drugs to play like Bird. I mean I don't want to say that that was the case, because I've never studied it that much, but there's no question that drugs were rampant in the bebop era, and were not rampant before that. So that's all I can say.

MR: Okay. I brought a little piece of music to play for you. It might jog your memory.

[audio interlude]

MR: It goes back quite a ways.

GW: Ruby Braff. "The Magic Horn." Am I playing piano there?

MR: Yes you are.

GW: I must have been reading the music or something. It doesn't sound like me. There's a funny story about that. We had this story, "The Magic Horn" was the story of a trumpet player and I guess Sal Mineo was the young guy, and Ralph Meeker. It was a television show. And I was the musical director. I put the band together. And — God I haven't heard that in ages — I wouldn't have guessed that — I knew it was Ruby, because nobody plays like Ruby. And so the story was the trumpet player who plays Sal Mineo was just an average trumpet player. And then when he got the magic horn he became a great trumpet player. So I never made it out this way. I had Jimmy McPartland playing the trumpet for the Sal Mineo before he got the magic horn, and Ruby Braff playing the trumpet from after he got the magic horn. And so I never told Jimmy. He just loved being in the show. He didn't know what was going on.

MR: He didn't know?

GW: I thought Jimmy McPartland was beautiful. But Jimmy didn't have the greatest chops in the world but he had a great musical head and he could play wonderful music. But Ruby had chops as strong as an elephant or a crocodile, he had chops. He could bite you like a crocodile too. So Ruby became the magic horn on television that Sal Mineo played. But that's nice to find that record. That's good.

MR: Yeah. That's part of our collection at the college.

GW: That's good. I had a lot of fun playing the piano. I played with great, great people. I played with Sidney Bechet and I did I think two albums with Bechet. I played with Buck Clayton and Vic Dickinson and Doc Cheatham and Buddy Tate and I did a week in Boston with Lester Young. Bird even came up and played with us one day in Storyville and we had a jam session in the afternoon. I mean, when I make a list, Buddy Rich and Gerry Mulligan, we recorded with them and Ruby and I at Newport, Bud Freeman, all these great players. I mean I played with them. The fact that I did and knowing that I wasn't in their league, but at the same time I didn't hurt them and the records I made sound nice. I listen to them, I enjoy them. There's a couple that are bad that I can't listen to. But most of them, because I'm my own severest critic. Because I know how badly I can play and I know when I don't play badly. Because I know my own weaknesses. And so I'm very proud of the way the records are made because the music on them is good.

MR: I'm glad you are still listening to them.

GW: I do listen to them once in a while. I think a lot of them haven't been put on out on CDs and I might make a compilation of a lot of them and print up a few hundred CDs to send to my friends so they can use them for whatever value or whatever they want to use them

for. But I am always impressed when there's — I've gotten some terrible reviews in playing the piano. I've had reviews where some said, "Those musicians wouldn't have played with George Wein unless he hired them." Well that might have been true, but that doesn't mean that that's the reason they played with me. Because many times they would call me and say, "Hey man are you available for the gig," you know, even though, who's going to play piano, are you going to play? Because they wanted me to play. Because I never got in their way. They knew what they could count on. But other times, Dan Morgenstern is one of my big fans. He's always written good things. The English critics have always said nice things. George Wein played nice piano, surprisingly. People didn't realize, surprisingly enough, George Wein played nice piano. That'll be on my tombstone, the epitaph. You know, I mean, we didn't know he could play like that. Every so often a musician comes up to me and says, "I heard this record, and the piano, I didn't know who it was, and I found it was you." He says, "man you were wailing." I love that. I mean that makes my day when that happens. Because a lot of people, you live with a lot of things when you're the producer and I've been — excuse the expression — I've been the man so long, producing festivals and everything. And you know when I first used to sit down at the piano they didn't think that I should sit down at the piano, a lot of critics. Who the hell was I to sit down at the piano? But man I love to play the piano. One time people said it's a bad use of power. Peter Watrous wrote that once. And I called Peter and I says, "You don't know what the word power means." I said, "I have no power. I have a little privilege because it is something, but power," I says, "power is what's happening at Lincoln Center now where they spend a hundred million dollars just to build a theater for Wynton and the Lincoln Center Jazz. That's power. I mean I'm scuffling to hire a musician to get him to work at a price that maybe we can make some money and he can make some money and I can break even at least, and let my sponsor pay the money. And every deal is a negotiation. Every single year we fight it out. We have no power. I mean I have the privilege of doing the business that I do and I work very hard at it and I enjoy it. And I try to make as many friends as I can as I go along. And a lot of the older musicians, we had our problems over the years, they're all friends of mine now. Because I was always consistent. They were consistent. And it we couldn't get together at one time one year, three or four years later we got together. And things change. The regular relationship changed, and I don't care who it is. I don't think I have any enemies among the older musicians. Maybe the younger musicians who are in the same position, I don't know. I don't even think I have many enemies among the younger musicians. At one time I had a lot of people who resented the fact that I was the man at the Newport Jazz Festival and they couldn't get on the festival unless I hired them. But I was still looking

for the right people. Hell it wasn't a matter of power. I hate that word. I hate it like poison.

MR: You've seen the business change an awful lot and I think it's to your credit that you've found a way to negotiate, as you say, through the changes. What do you think of jazz, like this whole thing that goes on here? Fifteen years ago—

GW: What's happening here, and we're on the archives, but this is 2001 in January and there are seven thousand people here for an IAJE jazz educator's convention. I've never seen anything like this in my life. Because I don't think these people know much about jazz. They're jazz educators but they don't have the knowledge that the people that used to come to the Newport Jazz Festival thirty years ago or forty years ago did. Because there was a concern about every musician that was on the stage. Who was playing bass? Who was playing drums? Who was the new drummer with Basie? You know, I mean everything. There was some concern. It was like Ted Williams was traded for Joe DiMaggio, you know, from the Yankees to the Red Sox, like when Cootie left the Duke to go to Benny Goodman, they wrote a song about it. That's the way jazz fans were in those days. I don't think people care like that anymore. They don't know that much. But there's some mystique about the word jazz that doesn't translate itself into record sales or ticket sales. And we have to compromise all the time at our festivals to draw people. By compromising I mean we have to play good music with a certain degree of credibility, but maybe not the purity of jazz. Because I don't know for sure what the purity of jazz is now. A lot of critics think that the purity of jazz has nothing to do with the jazz that I love. Ken Burns is being crucified because he's spending so much time with Louis Armstrong and Duke Ellington and the Swing Era, Wynton is always being shot at, at the same time they have everything going for them. They've got all the money in the world, they've got the subsidies and you have the Ken Burns jazz, you know, that Ken Burns is a man of jazz. At the same time the critics are killing him. There's no in between. There's no saying well what Ken Burns did was good for everybody that's involved with jazz. Because it is good for everybody that's involved with jazz. If you were a jazz musician and somebody says, "What do you do for a living" and you say, "I play jazz," there's a little more respect for you because of the Ken Burns show. "You play jazz. I don't know much about jazz but that must be an interesting life. I heard about this show. I saw this show on TV." The Lincoln Center jazz program is the most important institutional program for jazz in the world. That will spread to other cities, it already has spread to other countries, and as it spreads the different kinds of music will be involved. It won't just be what Wynton's idea of music is. Because other musical directors will become involved. Jon Faddis at Carnegie Hall has a totally different concept of music from Wynton Marsalis. There will be people with the new jazz, with contemporary things who

will find their voice, who will find their place. And it really is only because for the first time major institutions are supporting and raising money for jazz. So you don't have to criticize what Wynton does. Wynton is doing his thing. Wynton Marsalis is a breath of fresh air in the jazz world. I love Wynton. I can criticize Wynton. That's unimportant. I don't criticize him. I don't criticize any musician because they're doing their thing. And one of these days if their thing means something it will pay off. I don't know whether they're going to make millions of dollars but it will pay off in making a good living and being accepted as the artist they want to be accepted as.

MR: Wow. That's a good statement. And I appreciate you making it. I'm going to get you on your way here.

GW: All right.

MR: And I'm so appreciative.

GW: You get me to talk. I love to talk. I like things like this because I can say whatever the hell I want.

MR: That's right.

GW: I won't be on a panel. You'll never get me sitting on a panel. Because I don't like panels. You know, you want me to talk, if I can teach you something, if I can help you, or you can teach me something, great. Sitting on a panel — I was asked to be on a panel just recently and it was an interesting panel, but I said I had made a pact myself. I nearly weakened. And I had made a pact with myself. I wrote them a very nice note. I said, "I can't break the pact I made with myself, I won't sit on panels." Last year I did something. I organized with Bob O'Meally of Columbia a symposium. And I said to Bob, I said, "I don't want any of the older jazz critics in this symposium. I want a lot of the jazz educators and the younger writers, people that have been writing about jazz. We did it at Newport. Salve Regina College let us use the college. I called a bunch of different people and a few foundations and raised the little money we needed. We needed about fifty thousand dollars. I raised about thirty-five and I put in the balance myself. And we had the most fascinating symposium. Because I paid all the speakers, I think twelve, fifteen hundred or a thousand, I forget what it was. But they got an honorarium. But they had to write a paper and they had to speak for an hour, hour and a half, whatever time they wanted. And we'd have subjects. Now we might have two or three speakers on the same subject. But they'd have a different approach. But not a panel. Because I wanted something done on an intellectual level that didn't become self-serving. That they had — they weren't just complaining that their records weren't played on the radio or that they went in a record store and they couldn't find their records or that jazz is this or jazz is that. I wanted a point of view of people who were looking at this music, who have not lived this music. They were intellectuals. People with doctor's degrees, Ph.D.s, who are

now carrying the ball all over the country in universities. Many of these people are here right now. And it was fascinating. And we'll do that again. If we won't do it this year, we'll certainly do it next year. But it created a different kind of thing than the panel's discussion where you have four people and somebody talks for five minutes and then somebody says something and somebody says well I don't agree with that. I'm not interested whether you agree with it. Agree with it before or after the fact. And answer it in a paper. That's fine. But just don't — panels — I've been involved with panels for nearly 45, 50 years. And they never say anything. Because it ends up being, "No that's not the way I—" you know everybody. And I was very proud of that symposium. We made a lot of friends. What Bob O'Meally is doing up at Columbia is very important in his jazz studies program. And a lot of the older critics were a little upset with me until I wrote them a letter, Dan Morgenstern and Ira Gitler, I wrote them a detailed letter about, you know this is what you guys were fighting for all your life. These — a lot of them were African Americans — they were in universities teaching jazz. I says this is what you wanted. I says they will never know the jazz that you know. You lived it. I said but they're the ones that are going to be writing the books in the next twenty years. The history of jazz is in their hands. We have to reach these people. And so Dan Morgenstern came to the symposium as a guest. You know, he paid his own way to come. Because I invited them but they had to pay their way. Because there were 80 people. We didn't charge a fee, but they had to pay their own transportation. Dan came and he was treated so beautifully by these people because he was like the senior citizen that really was the expert. And they would keep calling — say, "Dan what do you think about it, Dan is this right?" Dan left there on cloud nine.

MR: Oh I'm so glad.

GW: And he's one of the sweetest guys you'd ever want to meet, Dan Morgenstern, and one of the most knowledgeable guys. But I didn't ask him to do a paper. I wanted a different point of view. The next year I may ask the older critics to do it. You see what I mean? Now that my point of view has come across and they realize why I did it. And I didn't make any enemies from it. It looked like I was making enemies, because they said "why aren't you using us, why are you using those people, they don't know anything about jazz." I says I know they don't know anything about jazz. I said but if they're going to be writing the books they better start learning."

MR: Well listen, I really appreciate your time. Thank you so much.

GW: It's a quarter to four, or quarter to five—

MR: All right, okay.

GW: I hope you got what you wanted.

MR: I did.

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